

English Paper 2

Reading Comprehension

Practice Paper #1

Name:

Duration: 35 minutes

Grade: 7

Marks: 25

Section:

Date:

Instructions:

1. Answer all the questions.
2. Write your answer to each question in the space provided.
3. You should pay attention to punctuation, spelling and handwriting.
4. The number of marks for each question or part question is shown in brackets []

Number of printed pages: **8 Pages**

Fourteen-year-old Noah is travelling home alone on a late bus after missing his usual stop. He is cold, tired and unsure what to do.

3 The bus lurches around the corner and Noah grabs the metal pole to stop himself sliding
4 off his seat. Through the smeared window he watches the familiar streets dissolve into
5 stretches he doesn't recognise – wider roads, orange-lit warehouses, a supermarket
6 shuttered for the night. His stomach tightens. He already knows he has gone too far.

7 He digs for his phone. His pocket is empty. He checks the other one, then his jacket.
8 Nothing. Of course. He'd left it charging on the kitchen counter. The realisation lands
9 like a stone dropping into cold water. He is stranded without any way to call for help.
10 He breathes in slowly, the way his swimming coach had always told him to before a race,
11 and tries to think.

12 The bus sighs to a halt at an empty stop. Rain clatters on the roof like loose change.
13 Almost everyone has gone now – just a few scattered figures hunched over their phones.
14 Then Noah notices the woman in the seat directly across the aisle. She is elderly,
15 wrapped in a long beige coat, and she is watching him with calm, pale eyes. On her lap
16 she holds a wicker basket covered with a square of checked cloth. She looks, he thinks,
17 like someone who has stepped out of a different century.

18 He turns away quickly, embarrassed to have been caught staring. But when he looks back
19 a few seconds later, she is still watching him with the same unhurried attention.

20 'You've missed your stop,' she says. It isn't a question.

21 Noah opens his mouth, then closes it again. 'How did you know?' he manages at last.
22 'You've been frowning at those houses for ten minutes,' she says pleasantly. 'And you
23 keep looking at the door as if you're hoping someone will come through it.' She shifts
24 the basket on her lap. 'I'm getting off at the next stop. Larkspur Lane. Do you know it?'

25 He doesn't. She seems unsurprised.

26 'Come with me,' she says. 'My neighbour has a car. He'll take you wherever you need to
27 go.' She pauses. 'You needn't look so alarmed. I'm perfectly harmless. Though I admit the
28 basket does look suspicious.'

29 Noah almost smiles. Almost. He is still calculating the risk, turning it over the way he
30 turns a smooth stone in his palm when he is anxious. Then the bus jolts forward and he
31 grabs the pole again, and something about the absurdity of it – sitting here, calculating
32 risks, clutching a pole in the rain – makes him give a short, involuntary laugh.

Later that evening, Noah writes in his journal.

34 Thursday

35 So here's what happened and I still can't quite believe it. I missed my stop (my fault,
36 I was half asleep) and I ended up going about seven stops past where I should have been.
37 No phone. Nothing. I was basically stuck.

38 There was this old woman on the bus. She had this massive wicker basket on her lap and
39 she just looked at me and said I'd missed my stop. She didn't even ask, she just knew.
40 She got me off the bus and her son – Mr Okeke, he was actually brilliant – drove
41 me home. I didn't even get her name.

42 I keep thinking about her eyes. They were so calm & still. Like she wasn't bothered by
43 anything. I don't know how to explain it. Mum would say I was being dramatic but it felt like
44 she knew things about me that I hadn't said. Like she'd read the next chapter already.

45 Is that what getting old does to you? Or maybe she was just one of those people who
46 pays attention. Either way, I owe her one. I keep thinking I might see her again, on the
47 same bus, with that same basket. I wouldn't be surprised. Nothing about her surprised me,
48 in the end. That's the strangest part of all.

49 N.

Section A: Reading

Spend **35 minutes** on this section.

Read the **text** in the insert, and answer **Questions 1–9**.

1 Look at **lines 1–11**.

(a) Noah is worried about his situation when he is on the bus.

Which **two** things tell the reader this?

•

•

[2]

(b) What does Noah's action of checking his pockets tell the reader about him?

Tick (✓) **one** box.

he is generally careless with his belongings

☐

he is panicking and cannot think straight

☐

he is realising how helpless his situation is

☐

he is relieved because he knows what to do

☐

[1]

2 Look at **lines 12–19**.

(a) Give a **two-word** phrase that describes the woman's way of looking at Noah.

[1]

(b) Give **one** word that means the same as 'at ease and untroubled'.

[1]

3 Look at lines 20–24.

Noah notices **two** things that suggest the woman has been watching him for some time.

What are they?

•

•

[2]

4 Look at lines 25–32.

Which of the following opinions do you agree with most?

Tick (✓) **one** box.

Noah is suspicious of the woman and does not trust her.

☐

Noah is gradually reassured by the woman's manner.

☐

Give **two** quotations that support the opinion you have chosen.

Explain how **each** quotation supports that opinion.

Quotation 1

Explanation 1

Quotation 2

Explanation 2

[4]

5 Look at lines 34–49.

Noah uses an informal style because he is writing in his personal journal.

Give **two** quotations that are examples of informal writing, and explain how each shows informality.

An example has been given.

Quotation: *(my fault, I was half asleep)*

Explanation: Uses brackets to add a personal aside in a chatty, casual manner

Quotation 1

Explanation 1

Quotation 2

Explanation 2

[4]

6 Look at lines 42–44.

(a) Give **one** word that means the same as 'completely untroubled'.

[1]

(b) What does the phrase '*she'd read the next chapter already*' in line 44 tell the reader about Noah's feelings?

[1]

7 Look at the final paragraph of the journal entry (lines 45–48).

What is the meaning of '*pays attention*' in this context?

Tick (✓) **one** box.

listens very carefully

☐

shows genuine interest in others

☐

remembers everything

☐

gives helpful advice

☐

[1]

8 Look at the text from line 34 to line 49.

What features tell the reader that this part of the text is a journal entry?

Give **two** features.

•

.....

•

.....

[2]

9 Look at the **whole text**.

(a) Both Noah and the woman seem to see something special in the encounter.

Give **one** phrase for each character that shows this.

Noah

.....

The woman

.....

[2]

(b) Look at the **whole text**.

Put these events into chronological order, numbering them from first (1) to last (5).

One example has been done for you.

Event	Order of events
Noah misses his stop	1
Noah is driven home by Mr Okeke	
The woman offers to help Noah	
Noah writes in his journal	
Noah notices the woman watching him	